

BEGINNINGS

My paternal ancestors were Jewish, mainly from Prague, Czechoslovakia, and Germany, all arriving in San Francisco in the early 1850's. My father's paternal grandfather was Philip Isaac Fisher and was both Levi Strauss's original accountant and the person who opened and closed Strauss's first store for him on a daily basis and served Strauss his entire career. My great-grandfather was not wealthy but at his death was financially comfortable. His wife died young, and his eldest daughter, Caroline or Cary, donned an important role caring for her siblings. My grandfather, Arthur Lawrence Fisher, the youngest of eight, adored Cary, who played partial surrogate mother. Born in 1875 in San Francisco, Arthur Lawrence Fisher grew, graduated from UC-Berkeley, and attended Johns Hopkins Medical School, graduating in 1900 and returning to San Francisco to practice medicine as a general practitioner. Later (perhaps in World War I but maybe earlier, during post-doctoral scholarship based research at Rockefeller University), he developed a specialty in orthopedics, becoming the third orthopedic surgeon west of the Mississippi and a founding member of the Western Orthopedics Society. In 1906, Philip Isaac Fisher died, stalling briefly Arthur Fisher's marriage to Eugenia Samuels. The marriage stalled again behind the infamous 1906 fire and earthquake. Finally they married, and my father was born the next year, on September 8, 1907. He was named originally Philip Isaac Fisher, after his recently deceased grandfather.

Four years later in 1911, my father's sister, his only sibling, was born. She was named Caroline after Aunt Cary. Aunt Cary had married well, to a Levi Strauss relative named Henry Sahlein, who was introduced to Cary through her father. Aunt Cary played an important role in the lives of Fishers for two generations, those of both my grandfather and father. Aunt Cary not only secretly bankrolled my father's education (some-thing he never, ever knew), but also secretly gave my grandfather money to buy a car for Father that became serendipitously seminal to his career evolution. And Cary provided ongoing family social structure that enriched Father's fragile emotional existence as a child—a process that continued for decades. If my parents had had a daughter, she would have been named Cary, as was their first grandchild.